

Practice Paper 23 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — How the wallet was first seen

1 mark for understanding that the wallet was **visible** / **obvious** / **easy to spot** (half open, leaning out).

1 mark for the **personification** — it appears almost deliberately placed, **as if it had a will of its own**, drawing his attention; this hints at fate or temptation.

Sample answer: The wallet is described as if it had been waiting for him, which **personifies** it and suggests that he did not have to search for it — it was **almost asking to be found**, as though chance, or temptation, had placed it before him.

Q2. [2] — Reasons to consider keeping the money

1 mark each for any two of:

- His shift was **nearly over** — he was **tired**.
- His **wife was ill** and waiting at home for dinner — he had domestic pressure.
- The owner had **paid in a hurry** and **not looked back** — discovery was unlikely.
- The owner lived **far out in the north** — returning the wallet would be inconvenient.
- “Nobody, in any practical sense, would ever know” — no one would catch him.

Q3. [2] — “Very briefly and very vividly”

1 mark — **Briefly** suggests the thought was **fleeting** / he did not dwell on it / it lasted only a moment.

1 mark — **Vividly** suggests that, in that short moment, the picture in his head was **startlingly clear and detailed** — the temptation was real and powerful, even if quickly dismissed.

Together: the contrast shows that he is **honest enough not to entertain** the thought for long, yet **human enough to feel its pull strongly** while it lasts.

Q4. [2] — Why he decides to return the wallet

1 mark — He has **built a record / a habit** of honesty over twenty-three years of returning lost items.

1 mark — He does **not wish to become a thief** at his age over something as small as a **tired evening** — his sense of **self-respect / consistency of character** outweighs the temptation.

Q5. [2] — “Cheerful indifference”

1 mark — **Personification**: the satellite navigation system is given a **human emotion** (cheerfulness), even though it is only a machine.

1 mark — The contrast: the machine is **cheerful but indifferent** — it does not care whether the journey matters; the narrator, by contrast, is making a **morally weighted, deliberate choice**. The machine’s casual tone **highlights the quiet seriousness** of what he is doing.

Q6. [3] — Quiet nature of his satisfaction (language question)

1 mark for identifying **the understated / restrained quality** of the pleasure; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “small, contained pleasure” — the adjectives **small** and **contained** show the pleasure is **modest and private**, not boastful.
- “not loudly but firmly” — the **contrast** shows his decision is **quiet but resolute**, not theatrical.
- “I told myself, several times, that I was not annoyed” — he is **managing his own emotions inwardly**, not performing virtue.
- “I did not, all that hour, touch it again” — the **self-restraint** with the wallet shows that doing right is something he does **steadily and silently**.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — Mr Tan’s three expressions

1 mark — The sequence shows Mr Tan is **unprepared** — he did not realise his wallet was missing, so first **surprise**, then **alarm** (realising what he had lost), then **suspicion**.

1 mark — The final **blankness** suggests he is **guarded / wary** — he is unsure whether the narrator is a Good Samaritan or someone who may have taken the wallet in the first place.

Q8. [1] — Evidence of distrust

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- He **counted the notes** before thanking the driver.
- He **patted at the cards** to check that nothing had been tampered with.
- He did **not quite meet the narrator’s eyes**.
- His thanks came only after a **small, awkward pause**.

Q9. [2] — What he had been hoping for

1 mark — He had hoped for a **warmer, more emotional thanks** — a handshake, an introduction to the wife, an invitation in for tea.

1 mark — He had hoped, secretly, for some kind of **recognition / human warmth / reward of feeling** that would **match the effort and goodness** of what he had done; the polite but cool response feels insufficient to him.

Q10. [1] — “The small private weather inside one’s own chest”

1 mark — Goodness is something **felt inwardly / privately** — it is about one’s own **inner emotional state / conscience**, rather than the outward reactions of other people. (Also accept: it is a **quiet, personal thing** and not for public display.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, resigned, quietly wise, sobered, philosophical, wistful**. (Reject: **bitter, angry** — these miss the gentle, accepting quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Unnoticed soundtrack of a productive summer afternoon”

1 mark for understanding **unnoticed** — bees were so common their sound was **taken for granted** / **barely noticed**.

1 mark for understanding **productive summer afternoon** — bees were a **constant background presence** during the **most fruitful season**, doing **essential work** that ordinary people did not consciously appreciate.

Q13. [2] — Losses “now barely make the agricultural papers”

1 mark — Losses of thirty to forty per cent would once have been seen as **shocking** / **catastrophic**.

1 mark — Such losses have now become so **routine and frequent** that they are **no longer treated as news** — society has begun to accept them as normal.

Q14. [2] — No single cause of colony collapse

1 mark — There are **several different pressures** acting on bees at the same time (chemical, biological, environmental).

1 mark — **None of these pressures** alone would kill a colony, but **combined** they overwhelm the colony’s natural defences.

Q15. [2] — Sub-lethal harm of neonicotinoids

1 mark — Even small amounts of the pesticide **do not kill the bee directly**.

1 mark — They **damage her memory and navigation**, so she cannot find her way back to the hive — this **indirectly** leads to the colony’s collapse.

Q16. [1] — “A well-adapted parasite”

1 mark — **Well-adapted** suggests the mite is **highly evolved** / **suited to its host**; it is able to **evolve resistance** to the chemicals beekeepers use against it, which is why treatments stop working over time.

Q17. [2] — “A buffet, not a banquet”

1 mark — **A banquet** = a **single, very large meal** eaten on **one occasion** — short, intense, then nothing afterwards; this represents the monoculture’s brief flowering.

1 mark — **A buffet** = a **steady, varied range of food** available **throughout the season**; this is what bees actually need — **small amounts of many flowers, spread over time**.

Reject answers that lift the phrase without explaining the contrast.

Q18. [2] — Modern farming damaging bee habitats

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Vast monocultures** offer flowers for only a few weeks, then nothing.

- The **loss of hedgerows, wild verges and small woodlands** through development and intensive farming.
- **Climate stress** — earlier flowering, hotter summers, sudden cold snaps — disrupting the timing of available food.
- Wild pollinators are losing habitat alongside honeybees.

Q19. [1] — Tone of “a thinner, blander, more uniform table”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **regretful, wistful, sober, quietly persuasive, understated**. (Also accept: **gently warning**. Reject: **cheerful, angry**.)

Q20. [1] — Italics on “pollinator strips”

1 mark — The italics mark out a **technical / specialist term** that the writer is **introducing to the general reader**; it signals that the phrase is being **defined or used in a specific agricultural sense**.

Q21. [2] — Effectiveness of the final image

1 mark — The image **returns the reader** to the opening “hum” of bees, giving the article a **satisfying circular structure**.

1 mark — It is **encouraging and practical**: it suggests that **small individual actions** (one flower at a time) **add up** to real change, **empowering the reader** rather than leaving them despairing.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Causes of decline (Paragraphs 3–5):

1. **Neonicotinoid pesticides** damage bees’ **memory and navigation**, preventing them from returning to the hive.
2. The **Varroa mite** feeds on bees and **spreads viruses** that weaken them.
3. The mite has **evolved resistance** to the chemicals used to control it.
4. **Monoculture farming** gives bees a brief glut of flowers, then nothing — an **unsteady food supply**.
5. The **loss of hedgerows, verges and woodlands**, plus **climate stress**, reduces and disrupts available food.

What is being done (Paragraph 7):

6. Commercial beekeepers are **breeding mite-resistant bees** and **sharing hive-health data**.
7. Some farmers are **planting wildflower strips** alongside their crops.
8. Individuals can **plant native flowers, leave lawns long, avoid neonicotinoid products, and leave out water** — small actions that together make a difference.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Honeybee populations are declining because pesticides absorbed into crops impair bees’ memory and navigation, while parasitic mites feed on them and spread viruses, having evolved resistance to treatments. Monoculture farming, vanishing hedgerows and unstable climates leave

bees short of varied, year-round food. In response, commercial beekeepers are breeding tougher stock and sharing health data, some farmers plant wildflower strips, and ordinary people can grow native flowers, leave lawns wild, avoid harmful chemicals and set out water.

Length count: 78 words from “Honeybee” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —